CITIZENSPEAK



SANDESH RAVIKUMAR

'Public sector lacks responsibility, accountability

PRASHANT PRAKASH, *57*
Founding Partner, Accel, India

Prashant Prakash has not only led investments in 30 Indian tech start-ups, he is also the chairman of the government's Vision Group for Start-ups, acting as a bridge between babudom and entrepreneurs. Being an old Bangalorean, he is not only concerned about where the city is headed but also deeply involved in its upliftment. "If there is one cause for Bengaluru's failures," he says, "it's the lack of capacity to design solutions and contract them for implementation that ensures outcomes." In many major projects, he says the design is given by a consulting agency that doesn't have skin in the game and implementation is by an agency that has no interest in making it cost-effective. "The city bears the brunt of the mistakes, especially environmental ones. The government sector is all about authority, but lacks responsibility and accountability." Prakash recommends setting up a coordinating body to govern infra across stakeholders and PPPs to ensure outcomes.

tioning of the BBMP apart from the BMRDA and the BDA, has also drawn flak for delaying the municipal polls to elect corporators and the mayor of the city. There have been no elections since 2020, as a new law passed that year by the assembly to expand the number of wards from 198 to 243 and to devolve more powers to the mayor is caught in a legal battle. Critics cite the delay as deliberate because Bengaluru is seen as the cash cow that generates an enormous amount of speed money or bribes to get clearances for licences to construct buildings quickly. With the assembly election due next year, the political class allegedly wants the ambiguity to persist in order to milk funds to fight the polls.

5. Bribe and Prejudice

This brings us to the fifth major reason for Bengaluru's decline: rampant corruption in civic bodies to get sanctions as well as clearance for land use, building construction and completion certificates. Every party that has ruled the state in the past few decades has been guilty of looking the other way. T.V. Mohandas Pai, the city's top angel investor, is blunt, "Everyone knows that the BBMP is a very corrupt organisation where posts are sold, people come there to make money for projects and there is no auditing, so nobody has been sacked. You can't start a project, get a building licence and electricity sanction unless you bribe them. It's getting worse by the year." Last year, to Bommai's acute embarrassment, one of the major contractors' associations in the state wrote a letter to the prime minister alleging that the ministers and elected representatives demand up to 30 per cent of the tender amount to approve a contract in addition to the 5-6 per cent towards the release of the 'Letter of Credit' against pending bills. Bommai dismisses the charges, saying after taking charge in July 2021, he constituted a tender scrutiny committee headed by a retired judge to prevent malpractices. Interestingly, the 28 MLAs who represent Bengaluru are among the richest in the state as the declarations before the Election Commission have shown, with B.S. Suresh, a Congress MLA from Hebbal, boasting a net

WATER WOES

2,100
MILLION LITRES
The daily demand for drinking water

650
MILLION LITRES
The daily shortfall, a third of the demand

Source: BWSSB website